

Harriet the Spy

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Nov. 3, 2002

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THE LITTLE FRIEND

By Donna Tartt.

555 pp. New York:

Alfred A. Knopf. \$26.

"She did not care for children's books in which the children grew up, as what 'growing up' entailed (in life as in books) was a swift and inexplicable dwindling of character; out of a clear blue sky the heroes and heroines abandoned their adventures for some dull sweetheart, got married and had families, and generally started acting like a bunch of cows." These reflections belong to Harriet Dufresnes, the smart, unsentimental 12-year-old heroine of "The Little Friend," Donna Tartt's large and satisfying second novel. As well as being an indomitable detective and an impressive underwater swimmer, Harriet is a

pretty good literary critic. There is, after all, a vast, wholesome body of juvenile literature whose purpose is to ease the passage of the protagonist (and, by implication, the reader) into the flat pasturelands of adulthood.

But there is also, alongside this bovine canon, a darker, wilder tradition, a long shelf's worth of coming-of-age stories (not all of them intended for children) in which the passage to maturity is a harrowing ordeal, and in which adult self-awareness arrives with the force of tragedy. As indeed it will for Harriet herself, after a long summer of peril, adventure, frustration and guilt -- of growing up, in other words. "Later, when Harriet remembered that day, it would seem the exact, crystalline, scientific point where her life had swerved into misery. Never had she been happy or content, exactly, but she was quite unprepared for the strange darks that lay ahead of her." In such books, the survival of the heroic child's character is precisely what is at stake, and those who triumph do so at a terrible cost. To grow up is to acquire the knowledge of cruelty and pain, to be initiated into the grim mysteries of experience and to live to tell the tale.

If Harriet seems unaware of the tradition to which she so clearly belongs -- or perhaps just too preoccupied with poisonous snakes, cretinous drug dealers, doddering aunts and an unsolved murder to read as widely as she might like -- the same can hardly be said of Donna Tartt. She has the insomniac sensibility of someone for whom reading has long been a matter of life and death, and clues to her taste litter the pages of "The Little Friend." Harriet, the child of a Mississippi family near the end of a long decline from gothic gentility to middle-class normalcy -- vestigial Compsons in a world long given over to Snopeses -- flourishes in the company of other brave, lonely schoolgirl heroines, many of them also residents of the Deep South. Through the lush, thorny thickets of Tartt's prose, you can catch glimpses of Faulkner's rambunctious Caddy, of Scout from "To Kill a Mockingbird," Frankie from "The Member of the Wedding" and, most delightfully, of another Harriet -- the sixth-grade spy from Louise Fitzhugh's children's classic.

Harriet shares some superficial traits with all of these characters: like Caddy, she is fond of climbing trees; like Harriet the Spy, she scribbles unkind observations in a notebook; as with Frankie, her closest confidante is the family's black housekeeper, Ida Rhew. But she is also linked to them by deeper affinities of temperament -- by a fierce, adolescent sense of right and wrong and by the dangerous habit of sticking her nose where it doesn't belong. If these aspects of her personality make her recognizable, they also make her memorable and unique: she is part of a literary sisterhood of smart, prickly loners, and as such she is likely to attract generations of loyal followers. "The Little Friend" seems destined to become a special kind of classic -- a book that precocious young readers pluck from their parents' shelves and devour with surreptitious eagerness, thrilled to discover a writer who seems at once to read their minds and to offer up the sweet-and-sour fruits of exotic, forbidden knowledge.

Tartt's first novel, "The Secret History" (1992), about the intellectual arrogance and murderous hubris of a group of college students, already enjoys a similar status. To read the book is to undergo an esoteric initiation rite -- to join a secretive cult made up of more than 5 million readers in 24 countries. Like its predecessor, "The Little Friend" will attract a mass of readers, all of them convinced that it was written especially for them.

"The Secret History" was a murder mystery in reverse. The crime and its perpetrators were given away in the prologue, and what followed was a terrifying exercise in existential forensics, a kind of "C.S.I." of the soul in which the detective went sleuthing after the sources of his own guilt. "The Little Friend" is, at least on the surface, a more conventional mystery, beginning with a killing that it will fall to Harriet to solve, even though it took place when she was just a baby. The victim was her 9-year-old brother, Robin, found hanging from a black tupelo tree one Mother's Day as his mother, grandmother and great-aunts fussed over a big family dinner. His death -- which, given the

Southern setting, cannot help evoking the grisly history of lynching -- accelerates the unraveling of Harriet's family, which had recently abandoned its ancestral plantation home (called Tribulation) for ordinary houses in town. By the time Harriet has reached the brink of puberty, her mother has retreated into a melancholic stupor and her father, a country-club vulgarian, has decamped to Nashville. So Harriet and her older sister, Allison, find themselves the protégées of a tattered matriarchy overseen by their maternal grandmother, Edie, and their childless great-aunts, Libby, Tat and Adelaide.

With an idle summer ahead of her and her family's unhappiness entangling her like kudzu vines, Harriet decides, with a child's superstitious clarity of purpose, to seek out her brother's killers. "What she wanted -- more than Tribulation, more than anything -- was to have her brother back. Next to that, she wanted to find out who killed him." With the help of Hely, a well-adjusted, shallow boy with a terrified crush on her, Harriet begins poking around and soon finds herself mixed up with the Ratliff brothers, one of whom, Danny, she makes her prime suspect. The Ratliffs, who run a methamphetamine lab in a shed on the edge of town, are like an infernal mirror image of Harriet's own family. Though their habits and dialect come close to caricature, their presence provides a jolt of scary, comic anarchy.

The brothers -- the rabidly paranoid Farish, the addlepatented preacher Eugene and the speed-crazed Danny -- are also testament to Tartt's profligate gift for inventing bold, complex characters and for ensnaring them in webs of accident and fate. Her feel for the social landscape of the New South -- the book takes place sometime in the 1970's, though Tartt is blessedly sparing with gratuitous period details and pop-cultural references -- is remarkably acute. She illuminates the persistence of racial injustice and class antagonism, and captures the region's Babel of accents and idioms, from patrician hauteur to Pentecostal fire and brimstone to chamber of commerce unctuousness. "The Little Friend" is overgrown with symbolism and spooky implication -- Tartt has a special

fondness for the creepy animal totemism of dead cats, dying blackbirds and poisonous snakes -- but it is also crowded with a bustling, ridiculous humanity worthy of Dickens.

What this all adds up to is a tragic, fever-dream realism. Though the world Harriet discovers is unquestionably haunted, there is nothing magical about it, or about the furious, lyrical rationality of Tartt's voice. Her book is a ruthlessly precise reckoning of the world as it is -- drab, ugly, scary, inconclusive -- filtered through the bright colors and impossible demands of childhood perception. It grips you like a fairy tale, but denies you the consoling assurance that it's all just make-believe.

Comparisons, in any case, are beside the point. This novel may be a hothouse flower, but like that fatal black tupelo tree, it has "its own authority, its own darkness." "This was the hallmark of Harriet's touch," Hely reflects. "She could scare the daylights out of you, and you weren't even sure why." Harriet's gift is also Tartt's. "The Little Friend" might be described as a young-adult novel for grown-ups, since it can carry us back to the breathless state of adolescent literary discovery, when we read to be terrified beyond measure and, through our terror, to try to figure out the world and our place in it.

A version of this article appears in print on , Section 7, Page 11 of the National edition with the headline: Harriet the Spy